

NAPLAN

State report – Year 3

December 2017

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Preface

The QCAA issues State reports on the performance of Queensland students on the National Assessment Program — Literacy and Numeracy (NAPLAN) tests. State reports provide system-level information and are publicly available. This report for Year 3 students in 2017 contains:

- the Queensland performance on each item
- the national performance on each item
- the item descriptors
- a commentary on the state results
- some recommendations for teaching.

Who should use this State report?

The NAPLAN State reports help principals, teachers and other school personnel understand, interpret and use information about student performance on NAPLAN.

School principals can use this report to provide information to the school community on aspects of the tests. This would allow professional conversations with their teachers, curriculum leaders, and department heads. Curriculum leaders can use this information to interpret the more specific information given in their school and class reports. These other reports are explained below.

Since this report is publicly available on the QCAA website, it can also inform providers of teacher training, special education services and educational research and policy.

Parents and carers can use this report to interpret the results on their child's student report. They are also able to judge how their child performed when compared with the whole population of students. The item descriptors provide them with useful information about the scope of the tests.

About the tests

The purpose of the National Assessment Program (NAP) is to collect information that governments, education authorities and schools can use to identify the important educational skills Australian students can demonstrate.. As part of that program, the NAPLAN tests are administered to full cohorts of students in Years 3, 5, 7 and 9 each year. These standardised tests are sources of information about literacy and numeracy learning that can be used to inform educational policy and current educational practice.

The NAPLAN tests were developed using the nationally agreed Statements of Learning for English and Statements of Learning for Mathematics, 2005. Since 2016 however, the tests now directly relate to the Australian Curriculum. The NAPLAN tests are designed to provide a nationally comparable indication of student performance in Language conventions, Writing, Reading and Numeracy. The tests are designed to assess student understanding in the following areas:

- Language conventions: The test assesses the ability of students to independently recognise and use correct Standard Australian English grammar, punctuation and spelling in written contexts.
- Writing: The test assesses the ability of students to convey thoughts, ideas and information through the independent construction of a written text in Standard Australian English.

- **Reading:** The test assesses the ability of students independently to make meaning from written Standard Australian English texts, including those with some visual elements.
- **Numeracy:** The test assesses students' knowledge of mathematics, their ability to apply that knowledge in context independently, and their ability to reason mathematically.

Marking and scoring the tests

Marking the tests

Markers mark those test items that do not use a multiple-choice format. These markers apply nationally-agreed marking guides. There are marking guides for open-ended Reading items if any such items are included. Marking guides allow consistent and reliable judgements by markers. There are guides for the Writing test and one each for the constructed responses in Numeracy and Spelling. For some Numeracy items, students may provide a correct response in different forms. Professional officers decide on agreed scoring protocols for these items.

Calculating raw scores

The simplest calculation made in scoring the tests is the raw score — the number of questions answered correctly. All of the questions for the Language conventions, Reading and Numeracy tests are marked as either correct or incorrect. Raw scores for the Writing test are sums of the marks on each of ten criteria.

Raw scores have limited use. They enable the performance of students who have all completed the same test at the same time to be placed in a rank order, but they do not provide information about the level of difficulty of the test nor the relative differences between students.

Constructing scaled scores and bands

To make raw scores more useful, they are transferred to scores on a common scale that reflects how difficult it was to achieve each score. Each year ACARA publishes equivalence tables that allow a student's raw score to be located on the NAPLAN scale. The scale is comparable between year levels for each assessment area. An equating process is also carried out on each year's test to enable scores to be compared between successive years of testing. For example, a raw score of 20 on the Year 3 Reading test might be transformed to a scaled score of 354. This will also represent the same achievement for a student with the same scaled score in Year 5, and for a student with the same scaled score for Reading in a previous year.

Each NAPLAN scale is divided into ten bands used to report student progress.

Using NAPLAN reports to inform teaching and learning

Using scaled scores

The scaled score can compare the results of different students. Scaled scores provide a basis for measuring and comparing students' abilities across years of schooling, for example, comparing a student's result in Year 3 in 2015 and Year 5 in 2017. The scales can thus help to monitor the growth of groups of students over time. This enables the school to review and/or consolidate special programs that may have been put in place.

Principals and teachers should take care when making comparisons between small groups of students. For groups of fewer than 10 students, differences may not be reliable, particularly small differences.

Using item analysis

While the national and state reports provide the comparative data, class reports provide a school with the information that can be used to inform teaching and learning and to build capacity in schools. Analysis of the NAPLAN class data, in particular the performance on each item, will provide teachers with information about the understandings and patterns of misunderstandings of students.

Looking at the performance on the items and then analysing the error patterns allows teachers and principals to make hypotheses about why groups of students make particular errors. As mentioned below, more detailed analysis by QCAA staff is available from the QCAA website.

Steps for analysis might be as follows:

- Compare the facility rates (percentage correct) achieved by the school's students with the national and state results available in this document. Is their performance consistent?
- Look at the common errors made by their students and compare them with the common errors made in the state (only errors from Queensland students are available, and are found in the item analyses that are part of SunLANDA Online).
- Form hypotheses about why students are making these errors, e.g.
 - How did students think about this aspect of the curriculum?
 - What misunderstandings might these errors represent?
 - How might the structure of the test question have shaped the response?

Using a combination of the NAPLAN data, school data and professional judgment, teachers may then test these hypotheses to see whether they are valid or whether there is more to be thought about and investigated. Teachers can then plan lessons related to the general areas where students seem to need help. Teachers can also make judgments about teaching approaches and curriculum.

The professional conversations that are part of this process are the most effective and powerful way to use the data, as they are the vehicle for developing shared understandings.

Placing the tests in the assessment context

The results from the NAPLAN tests should be seen as only one input into a school's assessment program. Various forms of assessment are needed to inform the different stages of the teaching and learning cycle. Principals and teachers should keep in mind that NAPLAN is a pencil-and-paper, point-in-time, timed test that can only cover a few curriculum features.

The results from a school's own assessments of students should be consistent with the NAPLAN test results. If the test results are different from what was expected, consider the possible reasons. The results of the tests may indicate aspects of student performance that need further investigation within the classroom, using other forms of assessment.

An item with a low facility rate (percentage correct) may not necessarily indicate a problem in teaching and learning. It may be that this was simply a difficult item for all students in this cohort across Australia.

Other NAPLAN reports

In addition to the State reports, the following reports are produced:

SunLANDA Online

Since 2015, student data has been released on the QCAA School Portal using the SunLANDA Online interface. State schools can access the data through One School. Access to SunLANDA as application software is also still available on the QCAA website.

SunLANDA Online provides class and school information in an electronic form that permits customised spreadsheet generation by users. In addition, it shows representative samples of students' incorrect responses to constructed responses where applicable. Hyperlinks from within SunLANDA Online lead to the QCAA's test item analysis. Information on how to use this service is available at: www.qcaa.qld.edu.au/p-10/naplan/test-reporting-analysis/sunlanda/accessing-navigating-sunlanda

Test Item analysis

These pdf documents contain analysis of each test item. They can be downloaded directly from the QCAA website. The analysis reproduces each item followed by expert analyses of how the item operated. It shows the distractors presented in multiple-choice items and explains students' reasoning.

School and class reports

The NAPLAN school and class reports are supplied electronically on the secure section of the QCAA website. These reports are accessible only with the school's Brief Identification Code (BIC) login and password. Individual student reports are distributed to schools as printed copies.

School reports

The QCAA issues NAPLAN School reports giving information about each school's performance. They provide a summary of year-level performance as well as performance by gender, language background and Indigenous status in the following fields:

- distribution of scaled scores
- distribution of achievement bands
- school and state means
- participation of the group.

The School report positions a school's performance within the state on a graph that is shaded to show the range of performance for the middle 60% of Queensland students together with the state mean.

Class reports

The QCAA issues NAPLAN class reports that show the performance of every student on every item. Under the name of each student is recorded the items they had correct and incorrect. They also show students' responses to constructed-response items.

The class report also gives the:

- percentage correct for each item for the class and state, and by gender
- scaled scores for each student
- performance bands for each student.

Individual student reports

The QCAA issues individual student reports to schools after the tests. Schools receive one printed report for each student to distribute to parents/carers.

ACARA Reports

As well as the Queensland reports from the QCAA, national reports are available from the website of the Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA). The *NAPLAN National Summary Report* and the *NAPLAN National Report* allow states and territories to place the achievement of their students in relation to their peers across the nation. This is system-level information and is publicly available.

Literacy

Writing

Stimulus (writing prompt) Years 3 & 5

YEAR 3 AND YEAR 5

Which is better?

Write a persuasive text to convince a reader that one thing is better than another.

For example, you might think that one game is more fun than another, one TV show is more enjoyable than another, or one invention is more important than another.

You can use your own ideas or you can use the ideas on this page.

Don't forget to give reasons for your ideas.

- **Start with an introduction.**
An introduction lets a reader know what you are going to write about.
- **Write your opinions on the topic.**
Give reasons for your opinions.
Explain your reasons.
- **Finish with a conclusion.**
A conclusion sums up your reasons so that a reader is convinced of your opinions.

Remember to:

- plan your writing
- use paragraphs to organise your ideas
- write in sentences
- choose your words carefully to convince a reader of your opinions
- pay attention to your spelling and punctuation
- check and edit your writing.



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About the task

In 2017, the NAPLAN Writing test was based on the persuasive genre. Two prompts were used, one for Years 3 & 5 and another for Years 7 & 9. The test conditions and administration remained the same as in previous years, i.e. teachers delivered the same spoken instructions and read the text aloud to students. Working independently, students had to plan, compose and edit a written response. Students were allowed five minutes to plan their script, 30 minutes to write and a further five minutes to edit and complete the task. Three pages were provided for students to write a response.

The 2017 prompt for Years 3 & 5 was titled *Which is better?* Students were asked, in the textual component of the prompt, to *convince the reader that one thing is better than another*. Some textual examples — a game, a TV show, an invention — were provided as suggestions. Additional information identified the structural components of a persuasive text and further defined these elements, e.g. *Start with an introduction. An introduction lets the reader know what you are going to write about*. Other notes were also provided in relation to the conventions associated with a writing task, e.g. *write in sentences, check and edit your writing* etc. Six photographic images accompanied by a further six adjacent comparative images were provided, e.g. a dog and a cat, fast food and healthy food.

The prompt was relatively open-ended, allowing students to base their writing on one or more of the comparative images provided, or one or more things of their own choice. Though the prompt indicated singularity (i.e. *Which **one** is better?*), nationally agreed convention permitted students to widen the comparison. Students who chose to mention a number of things did risk some loss of cohesion in their persuasive texts.

Markers for this Writing test were trained using the national persuasive writing marker training package, delivered as part of ACARA's national assessment program. Markers were recruited and trained in accordance with national protocols. For Queensland, registered teachers marked the NAPLAN Writing test. All markers applied the 10 criteria and related standards from the marking rubric. Writing test scripts were marked on screen in all states and territories. Stringent quality-control measures were applied to the marking of student scripts, including a prescribed percentage of scripts to be double-marked, and the daily application nationally of control scripts for all markers. As part of the Queensland marking operation for 2017, referee marking further ensured marker reliability. There was also provision for appeal over individual Writing test scores after the results were released. On appeal, a student's script was re-marked independently by two senior Writing test markers. A copy of the Persuasive Writing Marking Guide (2013) is available at: www.nap.edu.au/_resources/Amended_2013_Persuasive_Writing_Marking_Guide_-_With_cover.pdf

Performance

Anecdotal evidence from markers indicated that students in Years 3 and 5 were comfortable with the writing prompt, *Which is better?* The images provided were widely adopted by students as the basis for their persuasive texts, particularly the dogs/cats contrast. Cats did not generally fare well in these contrasts! A 'tour the stimulus' approach was less evident in 2017 than in some previous years. The relatively small group of students who diverged from the images provided on the prompt tended to write more challenging texts, though this was not exclusively so. In fact, students with a more sophisticated grasp of language were able to embed stylistic elements into the simple cat/dog or country/city comparison to provide a stronger sense of voice.

A closer adherence to the suggestions provided on the stimulus page appeared to be reflective of a general appropriateness for the age levels, rather than some absence of originality of ideas.

At first thought, the inclusion of a comparative element to the persuasive task may have provided greater challenge for younger writers but generally this was not evident. Students continued to

adopt fairly formulaic approaches to this persuasive text type, and whilst this broadly met the demands of the task (and rubric), it restricted a more natural flow of language and ideas. So, typically, an opening statement, such as *I firmly* (or *strongly* or even *passionately*) *believe*, would be followed by a series of body paragraphs, often introduced by the connectives *Firstly*, *Secondly*, *Thirdly* — concluding with a paragraph that provided a brief summation of arguments and ideas presented.

Students in Year 3, and to a lesser extent in Year 5, wrote in fairly straightforward sentence forms, with complex sentences common, but reflecting a limited range, e.g. *because*, *if*, etc. As far as possible, students should be encouraged to explore the full range of sentence structures, including the judicious use of short, sharp simple sentences and fragments for effect.

In terms of length of text, students in Years 3 and 5 tended to write a little more than the persuasive texts of previous years. This was encouraging. It is possible that the suitability of the prompt contributed to this trend. Obviously, students who were able to make use of a well-chosen adverb, adjective or nominal group could write with fewer words but with more demonstrable control of language.

A number of students used more varied openings to their texts to engage the reader. In some cases, this was productive.

ZZZ! Hear that? That is the sound of someone trying to play with their cat. Everybody knows that dogs are better than cats. (Year 3 student)

In other cases, the introductions appeared a little contrived, and failed to match the development of ideas (and tone) in the remainder of the text. Whilst cohesion is only one of the NAPLAN Writing criteria, the ways in which ideas, vocabulary, paragraphing and sentence formation work together is important to whole-of-text integration and reader understanding. Students should be encouraged to focus on ‘big’ ideas and construct their texts accordingly, ensuring consistency and sincerity of message without unnecessary gimmickry.

Relative areas of improvement from 2016 included the criteria of *Audience*, *Ideas* and *Punctuation*. The latter could possibly be because of the reduction in the use of direct speech, more associated with the narrative genre and generally more difficult. In terms of *Audience*, students wrote with greater confidence in their ability to express their personality and individuality. Since choice of *Ideas* was encouraged through the prompt, more students were able to draw on areas of interest and subject knowledge, e.g. apps, music, sport, reading genres etc.

WRITING

J.K. Rowling's books are better than David Walliams's
I believe that J.K. Rowling's books are better than David Walliams' books because of their endings, their characters and their original writing. Here is why...

Firstly, J.K. Rowling's endings are a lot better. The endings are always circular, so they go back to the beginning where they started. Also, the endings are FULL of surprises. David Walliams' books are nice, but they never seem to have the twist that people look for. Therefore, Rowling's books are better.

In addition, J.K. Rowling's characters are PERFECT! They are made up characters, so therefore they can have any personality she wants! Also, no other book has these characters, which means it is very easy to get original ideas. Consequently, J.K.'s books are the best!

DO NOT WRITE OUTSIDE THE BORDER

WRITING

Finally, J.K.'s books are VERY original. They are ^{definitely} different from any other book in any other bookshop. David Walliams' books are fun, but a lot of his characters are a bit like Roald Dahl's! He doesn't show it, but he always copies of him. I am positively sure J.K. Rowling's books are much better.

On the basis of the undeniable and the irrefutable evidence presented to you, I believe that J.K. Rowling's books are better than David Walliams' because of their endings, their characters and that they are SO original. So, when you get home, by a book by her and you WILL AGREE!

DO NOT WRITE OUTSIDE THE BORDER

Commentary on sample script

Many students who approached the Year 3/5 prompt tended to use the images provided on the prompt page as their subject matter. This student chose the more challenging comparison of two authors, J.K. Rowling and David Walliams, an interesting choice in its own right and a remarkable one for a student in Year 3.

It is quite difficult for younger students to escape the fairly formulaic approach to a persuasive text. After all, limitations in vocabulary, breadth of subject knowledge and familiarity with the genre restrict the capacity for students of this age to explore more original text forms. Whilst this persuasive text does follow a fairly traditional approach to a NAPLAN demand writing task, the writer has managed to 'colour' the text with an original voice, as well as demonstrate a control over this field of literature being discussed. The position in support of J.K. Rowling's work is clearly established in the introductory paragraph, previewing the body elements of the text that are subsequently developed (circular plots, unique characters, and originality of stories), culminating in a positive conclusion that invites the reader to engage with Rowling's work.

This young writer has experimented with a range of persuasive techniques that do, on the whole, succeed in engaging the audience and begin to persuade. Features such as emphasis (*FULL of surprises; characters are PERFECT!; SO original*), concession and counter argument (*David Walliams books are nice, but they never seem to have the twist that people look for*), contrast (*Also, no other book has these characters*), and personal address to the reader (*So when you get home, by [sic] a book by her and you WILL AGREE!*).

The vocabulary is mature, and is generally contextually appropriate. There is an occasional clumsiness in construction and language choice (*definitely different, positively sure; endings are a lot better*), but these examples are outweighed by an overall strength of vocabulary use, e.g. *original writing; endings are always circular; undeniable, and the irrefutable evidence*.

A range of sentence forms add depth and interest to the presentation of argument, particularly through the use of conjunctions and connectives that tightly link evidence and contention, e.g. *also, therefore, in addition, consequently, on the basis of, so, when*. Spelling, punctuation and paragraphing had a very high degree of accuracy for such a young writer. This is a very commendable effort.

Language conventions

Spelling

Results and item descriptions

The percentage columns give the facility rate (percentage correct). These results are based on provisional data.

Item	Answer	Qld %	Aust%	Description
Proofreading — Error identified				
1	grow	85.47	85.97	Correctly spells a one-syllable word with the vowel digraph -ow.
2	bell	86.99	88.41	Correctly spells a one-syllable word ending in -ll.
3	mother	72.02	75.33	Correctly spells a two-syllable word with a short vowel sound.
4	shoe	62.75	66.65	Correctly spells a one-syllable word with an uncommon letter pattern -oe.
5	splashed	77.67	79.02	Correctly spells a one-syllable word with a suffix -ed.
6	soil	46.77	47.16	Correctly spells a one-syllable word with the vowel digraph -oi-.
7	prize	50.35	52.46	Correctly spells a one-syllable word ending in -ze.
8	playground	59.17	58.94	Correctly spells a two-syllable compound word with the vowel digraph -ou-.
9	ocean	36.68	37.55	Correctly spells a two-syllable word with an unstressed final syllable.
10	churches	52.65	52.19	Correctly spells a two-syllable plural word ending in -es.
11	knowledge	23.88	27.46	Correctly spells a two-syllable word with an initial silent k-.
Proofreading — Error not identified				
12	trick	70.53	72.58	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a one-syllable word ending in -ck.
13	first	70.22	72.35	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a one-syllable word with the r-influenced vowel -ir-.
14	native	52.94	57.8	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word ending in -ve.
15	noise	62.50	64.43	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a one-syllable word ending in -se.
16	bucket	43.91	49.3	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word ending in -et.

17	fighting	42.86	46.38	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word with the long vowel sound /a/ represented by -igh-.
18	everybody	41.55	47	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a multisyllable compound word with an elided syllable.
19	equal	18.88	22.86	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word ending in an unstressed syllable -al.
20	explained	16.61	18.85	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word with the vowel digraph -ai-.
21	thread	15.13	15.35	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a one-syllable word with the vowel digraph -ea-.
22	laughter	17.83	20.28	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word with the digraphs -au- and -gh-.
23	relief	13.84	15.27	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a two-syllable word with the vowel digraph -ie-.
24	tricycle	7.29	10.11	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a three-syllable word with a prefix tri- added to a base word with the short vowel sound /i/ represented by -y-.
25	strawberries	9.24	11.57	Identifies an error, then correctly spells a three-syllable plural word requiring a -y to -ie- change.

About the test

The 2017 Year 3 test involved the following spelling features:

vowels: *thread*, *relief*, *laughter*, *fighting*, *first*, *explained*, *soil*, *shoe*, *mother*

complex consonants: *noise*, *prize*, *bucket*, *trick*, *ocean*, *bell*

inflections: *strawberries*, *explained*, *churches*, *splashed*

silent letters: *laughter*, *knowledge*, *fighting*, *grow*, *everybody*

compound words: *strawberries*, *everybody*, *playground*

unstressed final syllables: *equal*, *bucket*

affixes: *tricycle*, *native*

Performance

Year 3 students in 2017 performed similarly to last year. Queensland was below the national average on all words except *playground* and *churches*, though the differences were mostly not significant. The gap was notable on *bucket*, *everybody*, *equal*, *fighting* and *shoe*.

Many students omitted giving any response to the difficult items in the second part of the spelling test. The highest omission rate was 17% for the word *strawberries*.

Student error patterns reveal that many of them over-rely on 'sounding out' spelling strategies, especially when confronted with less familiar words, for example 'soyel', 'eque' and 'trisicle'.

The proofreading format used in NAPLAN may lead students to show different spelling behaviour than when they spell to dictation or when they generate spelling in the course of composing their own sentences. Teachers should judge the results in this context.

Implications for teaching

Please refer to the extensive discussion of the teaching of spelling in the NAPLAN State Report for last year, 2016. State reports of previous years are available on the QCAA website.

Testwiseness

Attempt all questions: Students need to pace themselves through the test. They should make an attempt and move on, leaving enough time to come back to the doubtful answers.

Read the word in context: The first section of the test identifies the misspelled target word with a circle. But the circled word alone is sometimes misleading. Students must read the word within the context sentence. For example, some students saw 'soyl' and decided the target word was 'soul', but the sentence shows that the real target was *soil*.

Beyond 'sounding-out'

Phonemic awareness: Students have to learn how the sounds match letters alphabetically in many single-syllable words. Students need phonemic awareness or the ability to hear all the sounds inside a word and they need alphabetic knowledge of the sounds of each letter. Next, patterns containing more than one letter are learned, such as the digraph oi for that diphthong sound and the CVe pattern whereby a long vowel sound is shown by a final e.

Morphemic awareness: Students then learn about the chunks of letters with grammatical meanings. These chunks include plural inflections, tense inflections, prefixes and suffixes.

QCAA resources

Please refer to the extensive discussion of the teaching of spelling in the NAPLAN State Report for last year, 2016. State reports of previous years are available on the QCAA website.

Full reports on student performance and error patterns on each item are published in the SunLANDA program and as PDF documents at www.qcaa.qld.edu.au/p-10/naplan/test-reporting-analysis/test-item-analysis

Grammar and punctuation

Results and item descriptions

The percentage columns give the facility rate (percentage correct). These results are based on provisional data.

Item	Answer	Qld %	Aust%	Description
26	D	92.53	93	Identifies the correct pronoun to complete a simple sentence.
27	A	83.48	84.18	Identifies the correct determiner in a simple sentence.
28	C	79.87	80.71	Identifies the correct conjunction to join two main clauses to form a compound sentence.
29	D	80.83	82.26	Identifies a question.
30	C	79.39	78.7	Identifies the correct contraction for could not.
31	A	78.16	78.8	Identifies the correct dummy subject for a noun clause in a complex sentence.
32	A	60.73	62.13	Identifies an error in verb tense.
33	B	63.23	65.12	Identifies the logical order and connection of clauses in a complex sentence.
34	B	75.57	74.12	Identifies the action verb in a complex sentence.
35	C	56.35	58.35	Identifies the sentence boundaries of a complex sentence.
36	C	50.53	50.48	Identifies a complete sentence.
37	B	72.8	72.63	Identifies an adverb in a complex sentence.
38	B	50.94	51.53	Identifies the correct punctuation of a list in a simple sentence.
39	C	60.77	62.57	Identifies a place noun in a simple sentence.
40	A	49.41	51.16	Identifies a contraction that grammatically matches a sentence.
41	B	35.86	35.88	Identifies the correct use of the article a with a word starting with u- .
42	D	45.09	46.61	Identifies the correct punctuation of a list in a simple sentence.
43	D	50.91	51.63	Identifies a simple command.
44	A	27.01	26.85	Identifies the correct punctuation of a sentence containing reported speech.
45	B	30.47	29.86	Identifies the logical order and connection of clauses in a complex sentence.
46	A	32.23	32.35	Identifies the incorrect use of a preposition instead of a

				verb in a simple sentence.
47	D	18.46	17.39	Identifies a given word as a noun in a simple sentence.
48	C	24.15	22.4	Identifies the reason for the use of an apostrophe in a simple sentence.
49	D	28.57	27.94	Identifies a contraction that grammatically matches a sentence.
50	D	6.83	6.79	Identifies two pronouns in a compound sentence.

About the test

The NAPLAN Language conventions items test sentence-level, clause-level and word-level skills. The test does not cover the curriculum. Instead, it tells how a large number of students perform on a small range of tasks. Standardised tests can, however, suggest broad trends across a cohort. At the level of individual students, NAPLAN results can supplement classroom assessments and guide teachers to important points of grammar and punctuation that need revisiting.

The 2017 Year 3 test involved the following features:

- Pronoun use (Items 26, 31, 50)
- Apostrophes used for contraction and possession (Items 30, 40, 48)
- Verb and verb tense (Items 34, 46)
- Articles and determiners (Items 27, 41).

These areas have been familiar components of previous Year 3 Language conventions tests.

For information about the full range of grammar knowledge that Year 3 students should have, refer to the *Australian Curriculum English*.

Performance

The performance of Queensland Year 3 students in Grammar and punctuation was comparable with the national cohort. Queensland students were closer to the national mean on this strand, compared with the other strands of Spelling, Reading and Numeracy that were also assessed in a multiple-choice format.

Strongest results were achieved in Item 34 (identifying an action verb), Item 47 (identifying a noun – *arrival*) and Item 48 (apostrophe of contraction).

Weakest results when compared with national facility rates were in Item 29 (identifying the need for a question mark), Item 33 (correct ordering of clauses), and Item 35 (correctly punctuating a complex sentence). It should be said that these results, both strongest and weakest, were not significantly different from national means.

A pleasing feature of the performance of Queensland Year 3 students on this year's test was the relative strength of results in the final set of items, which tended to be the most difficult. Relative to national means, Queensland students were stronger on 6 of the final 7 items on the test. Undoubtedly, teacher emphasis on an ordered, systematic and persistent approach to the whole test by students is being rewarded.

Implications for teaching

Grammar and punctuation is not a separate area but a component of reading and writing. The contexts of language in use are pivotal to a full understanding of how syntax, grammatical and punctuation conventions operate. Wherever possible, meaning and purpose in texts should be emphasised, noting how particular language conventions contribute to making meaning. Of course at Year 3 level, the systematic introduction of punctuation and the more straightforward grammatical features is essential. Teachers are encouraged to revisit things that NAPLAN targets, as they often represent fundamental conventions and usage.

Metalinguage

Success in the 2017 Language conventions test relied to some extent on a degree of metalinguistic knowledge and understanding. This feature of the test has become more apparent in recent years, and is also significant in testing at Years 5, 7 and 9.

Terminology like *contraction* (Item 30), *verb* (Items 32 & 34), *command* (Item 43), *apostrophe* (Item 48), *pronoun* (Item 50) and *direct speech* (Item 44) are now commonplace in NAPLAN Language conventions tests. Clearly, the teaching of these terms is essential for many reasons other than NAPLAN success. A common language between teacher and student, student and student and even test constructor and student is an enabler for student language improvement. However, knowledge of grammatical terms, by itself, is not sufficient for students' language growth. Students must be encouraged to see language in context, to look at linguistic concepts within the frame of making meaning, and even to recognise how parts of speech can fulfil different roles. This latter understanding is less significant at Year 3 level, of course, when foundational concepts are established.

Testwiseness

Although NAPLAN is a test of written, standard, Australian English, it often uses example sentences that seem to be from informal, spoken situations. Familiarity with diverse types of texts may help students to be more confident in viewing the NAPLAN items. Guide students through notable grammar and punctuation in a wide selection of reading materials, including texts that are challenging and divergent in form.

QCAA resources

Please refer to SunLANDA, which is available to schools via the QCAA Portal on the QCAA website through the school BIC and password. The SunLANDA program displays the school's results but also links to detailed analysis of every item on the NAPLAN test. The analyses include Australian Curriculum links, language resource texts and other QCAA materials. The item analysis is also available collected into PDF format on the NAPLAN pages of the QCAA website.

Reading

Results and item descriptions

The percentage columns give the proportion of correct answers (facility rates). These results are based on provisional data.

Item	Answer	Qld %	Aust%	Description
<i>Safe in the storm</i>				
1	D	94.23	94.61	Locates directly stated information in a very simple narrative.
2	D	91.32	91.94	Links directly stated information across sentences in a very simple narrative.
3	A	90.43	91.34	Interprets directly stated information in a very simple narrative.
4	B	92.05	92.78	Locates directly stated information in a very simple narrative.
5	A	67.71	70.45	Identifies the purpose of an apostrophe in a very simple narrative.
6	C	74.6	76.01	Identifies the meaning of the title in a very simple narrative.
<i>Getting to school</i>				
7	C	59.8	62.96	Interprets directly stated information in a simple persuasive text.
8	B	82.29	83.88	Interprets directly stated information in a simple persuasive text.
9	B	77	80.13	Interprets directly stated information in a simple persuasive text.
10	A	58.81	59.57	Interprets a character's motivations in a simple persuasive text.
11	C	54.27	55.25	Interprets information from different sections of a simple persuasive text.
12	B	48.66	49.46	Identifies the main idea of a simple persuasive text.
<i>Bubbles</i>				
13	D	70.89	70.97	Identifies the first-person narrator in a poem.
14	B	44.16	44.57	Interprets the meaning of vocabulary in a poem.
15	D	43.63	42.3	Interprets the meaning of a phrase in a poem.
16	C	73.78	74.51	Interprets the meaning of a description in a poem.
17	A	73.06	75.14	Interprets the meaning of a sentence from descriptive language in a poem.

18	B	79.73	81.1	Infers the meaning of a description from context in a poem.
19	A	50.09	51.29	Analyses information across stanzas in a poem.
<i>Classroom robot designer</i>				
20	A	35.39	37.02	Identifies the main purpose of an advertisement.
21	B	22.7	24.07	Identifies the main purpose of the first paragraph of an advertisement.
22	D	35.62	37.45	Infers the purpose of a detail in a section of an advertisement.
23	D	29.08	31.45	Analyses the tone of the first paragraph in an advertisement.
24	C	30.82	31.56	Analyses information across the text in an advertisement.
25	D	36.22	37.62	Interprets the meaning of a phrase in an advertisement.
26	D	45.5	48.82	Locates directly stated information in an advertisement.
<i>Something to write on</i>				
27	B	52.31	55.58	Identifies the genre of an information report.
28	A	38.27	37.94	Locates directly stated information in an information report.
29	C	30.02	30.11	Infers a key idea from a paragraph in an information report.
30	C	57.71	58.74	Infers a key idea in an information report.
31	D	28.25	28.65	Links directly stated information across sentences in an information report.
32	B	29.14	28.72	Interprets the meaning of a phrase in an information report.
<i>Tiny houses</i>				
33	AE	22.24	23.99	Identifies the purposes of an information text.
34	C	24.06	24.06	Identifies an opinion in an information text.
35	D	24.32	25.94	Identifies the main idea of a paragraph in an information text.
36	AD	16.07	16.96	Links an illustration to information in an information text.
37	A	34.22	35.54	Links information across sentences in an information text.

About the test

In 2017, the Year 3 Reading test consisted of 37 items based on six reading magazine units with the following text-types or genres:

information — *Something to write on* (about paper) and *Tiny houses*

persuasion — *Getting to school* (a classroom discussion) and *Classroom robot designer* (an advertisement)

poetry — *Bubbles*

imaginative narrative — *Safe in the storm*.

Most items had a four-option, multiple-choice format. However, Item 33 required students to choose two options out of a possible five. As expected, there was a pattern of increasing difficulty across the test.

Performance

It was pleasing to see that 95.6% of Queensland students performed at or above the national minimum standard, compared to 95.0% nationally.

The facility rates for the first unit, *Safe in the storm*, were relatively high, due to the prevalence of items requiring students to locate explicitly stated information in the text. Facility rates decreased when students had to make more text-based inferences in the next unit, *Getting to school*. Item 12, for example, required students to infer the unmentioned question to which the students in the text are responding. The lower facility rate of 48.66% for this item suggests that students need to develop their ability to make inferences. This pattern continued throughout the unit, *Bubbles*, with students performing fairly strongly in literal questions, but less so for inference questions.

Classroom robot designer had the lowest facility rates of all the units in this year's test. Items 21 and 23 proved the most difficult in this unit. Item 21 asked students to identify the subject matter of the first paragraph, which is a fairly basic text-based interpretation. The low facility rate for this item might be attributable to the students' lack of familiarity with the 'three Rs' idiom. Most students believed that the first paragraph of the text was asking whether robots could help students to learn. However, this question is asked explicitly only in the second paragraph. Students need to consider the entire text when responding to text-based inference questions.

For Item 23, more students chose option B over the key, option D. Items that require students to identify the tone of a text, such as this one, often present challenges for students. Perhaps the general low facility rates for this unit stem from the fact that the purpose of this text – to persuade students to enter a competition to help design classroom robots – might not have been apparent to students.

Something to write on was a fairly complex text and was a link unit that also appeared in the Year 5 Reading test. Most students could identify the genre of the text (Item 27) and make a simple text-based inference regarding the advantages of paper over stone as a writing material. However, items which required students to connect information from different parts of the text were handled less successfully by students. Item 31 (28.25%), for example, asked where the word *paper* comes from. Although the text states explicitly that '*paper*' comes from the word '*papyrus*', students needed to return to an earlier section of the text to confirm that papyrus is a reed plant.

Facility rates for *Tiny houses* were very low. To a large extent the low facility rate might be due to the prevalence of items requiring students to make inferences regarding the purposes of the text (Item 33), the main idea of a paragraph (Item 35) and the purpose of an illustration in an information text (Item 36). However, the difficulty of Items 33 and 36 was compounded by the fact that students had to choose two options. Although in both cases most students chose two

options, only a relatively small percentage chose the two correct responses. Partial marks are not awarded in NAPLAN tests.

In summary, Year 3 students demonstrated a high capacity to answer literal (recall and translation) type items. However, there were only 13 items of this type out of 37 on the paper, and most of these (12) were in the first three texts in the test. But items that involved purpose, tone and character had lower facility rates than literal and lower-order inferential items. This is because they required higher-order reasoning and comprehension. Students had to form an understanding of the whole text as well as pay attention to subtle clues in the text that help them make the inferences.

Implications for teaching

The low facility rates on non-literal items demonstrate the importance of giving students strategies to help them make inferences as they read, i.e. to make statements about the unknown based on the known. Items that involve purpose, main idea, theme or tone of the text (in whole or part), challenge students. They have to understand the whole of the text to answer the item.

The challenge for teachers is to get students to read a variety of authentic and well-written texts. The teacher guides students through reading stages. In the first stage, we take an overview. What sort of text does it look like? What does it seem to be about? What do I think already about the topic? Use discussion groups to explore existing ideas on the text topic so that students can be on the lookout for what the text says that differs from what they expect.

Help students through a scanned reading of the text to identify the main structural components. Note how the parts of the text contribute towards a main idea and to the meaning of the whole. This is the time to discuss patterns (e.g. cause and effect, contrast, comparison). Teachers are the facilitators of this process of annotating and discussing texts; they are not the leaders. Their focus should be on:

- modelling a love of books and reading
- finding authentic texts which appeal to children of that age
- providing a range of genres and a range of narrative texts, from traditional texts to texts with postmodern elements
- promoting higher-order thinking about texts
- reading aloud to students to promote reading for pleasure
- developing an awareness of how the parts of the text combine to create a whole through both semantic (links between the ideas) and syntactic (grammatical links) cohesion
- encouraging students to make inferences as they read (an informed guess backed by evidence from the text)
- encouraging students to see connections between the text and their own knowledge and experience, between different things within the text and between this text and other texts in a similar genre or on similar subject matter
- encouraging students to be active readers and make connections between the text and their own knowledge, experience and feelings.

At Year 3, this structural knowledge and approach needs to be activated delicately. A number of students are still grappling with basic word and grammar decoding issues. In a test setting, students will handle the distractors in the items much better if they are clear about the subject matter and the purpose of the text before they proceed to the items.

Students need practice with persuasive texts as they need to notice how modality is managed by the writer and how this affects certainty and obligation. Being able to discern a text's tone, mood and purpose are always very challenging for students in persuasive and narrative texts at all levels. Students should be encouraged to read with a pencil and highlighters in hand, to identify main ideas, visual and text features (e.g. figures of speech, use of data). It is not too early to get students in Year 3 to check for fallacies and persuasive techniques, to draw attention to emotive language and literary techniques and to check for comparisons and contrasts within the text.

Teach students to identify the main parts of a text. Show how to locate the main idea in each part. How do the main ideas relate to the author's purpose and what they hope the text will achieve? This skill is targeted in Item 35, where students had to identify the main idea from paragraph 2 of the *Tiny houses* text.

Teachers need to encourage students to read for pleasure and recreation in order to extend their knowledge of themselves and the world around them. Reading develops a reader's empathy for people in different situations. The complexity of the reading process is made visible when students discuss texts and share how they arrive at their personal understanding of the text.

Testwiseness

The stimulus texts that are used in reading tests are usually extracts from larger works or texts created to look like extracts. Students should be aware that these will be texts where some things are not clear. They should learn not to panic if the subject matter is not completely accessible, as in a poem such as *Bubbles*.

QCAA resources

Teachers can view school-specific performance information through the QCAA's SunLANDA Online program. SunLANDA Online is available through the School Portal on the QCAA home page. State schools can also access this content through OneSchool. SunLANDA Online displays the performance of classes, subgroups, and individuals within the school and compares the school's performance with that of the state and nation. Most importantly, hyperlinked to each item are analyses and teaching ideas.

QCAA 2015, *Beyond NAPLAN: How to read challenging texts*, Beyond NAPLAN series, http://www.qcaa.qld.edu.au/downloads/p_10/naplan_read_challenging_texts.pdf

Numeracy

Results and item descriptions

The numeracy strands are abbreviated as follows: Number and Algebra (NA); Measurement and Geometry (MG); Statistics and Probability (SP). All items are worth one score point. For the purpose of this report, the SunLANDA strands of number and algebra, functions and patterns have been combined as number and algebra to reflect the Australian Curriculum strands.

The percentage columns give facility rates (percentage correct). These results are based on provisional data.

	Strand	Answer	Qld %	Aust %	Description
1	NA	C	96.84	97.14	Counts the number of parts on an object.
2	MG	B	93.52	94.2	Identifies the container that is half full.
3	NA	19	88.68	91.01	Adds numbers to less than 20.
4	NA	C	64.92	68.23	Represents multiplication as repeated addition.
5	NA	A	84.77	85.93	Selects a numerical representation of a number written in words.
6	SP	B	90.41	89.67	Identifies which event is most likely to occur.
7	NA	B	86.72	87.76	Determines half of the number of items in a display.
8	SP	B	85.37	86.13	Interprets a table and identifies matching data in a tally table.
9	NA	23	43.55	45.82	Solves a subtraction problem.
10	MG	A	78.19	78.45	Identifies the effect of a one-step flip.
11	NA	65	63.87	65.8	Counts a small collection of notes.
12	NA	E	43.54	44.18	Calculates multiples of a unit fraction to complete a whole.
13	NA	D	59.45	61.92	Uses an addition pattern to determine the sum of the next two terms in a sequence.
14	MG	D	64.15	65.67	Adds half an hour to the time on a clock.
15	NA	47	51.4	55.8	Adds three one- and two-digit numbers.
16	SP	C	70.04	71.21	Reads information from a simple two-way table.
17	MG	13	76.89	79.15	Measures the length of an object using another object as the informal units.

18	NA	B	59.97	59.58	Locates three, two-digit numbers on a number line.
19	MG	C	67.98	68.87	Compares the weights of three objects using a balance scale.
20	NA	325	55.56	58.28	Counts efficiently by using groups of hundreds, tens, and ones.
21	NA	A	39.65	42.99	Selects the correct division equation represented by a model.
22	NA	5	39.97	42.32	Solves a simple problem using groups of equal sets to represent division.
23	SP	C	55.48	56.84	Identifies a question that would result in the given column graph.
24	NA	D	27.27	28.83	Identifies the correct number sentence to model a 'how many more' problem.
25	NA	D	42.98	45.11	Selects the correct number sentence to solve a problem using multiplication.
26	MG	3;4	26.23	28.26	Compares features of different three-dimensional models.
27	NA	7100	18.92	21.95	Represents a four-digit number using words and digits.
28	MG	D	28.03	27.54	Follows simple directions to locate a position.
29	NA	30	22.84	26.12	Solves a multi-step problem using the multiplication facts of two, three and five.
30	MG	B	31.57	33.91	Compares the capacity of objects using informal units.
31	MG	B	20.45	20.65	Compares weights read from an analog scale by subtraction.
32	SP	A	30.58	32.62	Selects a picture graph to represent given data where one picture represents many data values.
33	MG	4:20	5.92	7.88	Calculates the duration of time in a multi-step problem.
34	NA	140	5.58	6.84	Completes a number sentence showing two additions of equal value.
35	NA	53	11.31	13.98	Adds and subtracts two- and three-digit numbers to solve a multi-step problem.
36	NA	60	3.26	3.8	Solves a problem with three unknowns using addition.

About the test

The NAPLAN Numeracy test consists of 36 items covering concepts and skills from three strands. This year there were 21 Number and algebra, 10 Measurement and geometry and 5 Statistics and probability items.

Items with notable challenges for students included:

Item 5 and 27 – recognise and represent numbers with internal zeros

Item 10 – translating a shape with internal shapes

Item 12 – adding reference to 2 tubes where some students assumed one tube

Item 17 – use of informal units to measure an object and not starting at the equivalent 'zero' point (in previous years the 'broken ruler' was used)

Item 18 – students had to find multiple numbers, not listed in order, on a number line

Item 28 – semantically demanding

Item 33 – students had to factor in the clause, '...which was 15 minutes late.'

Performance

Queensland students performed better than the national facility rates in three items (6, 18, 28). The number of Queensland students answering the items correctly ranged from 97% for the first item to 3% for Item 36. This trend is typical of NAPLAN numeracy test performance.

While the majority of students attempted to answer all test items, a number omitted the more difficult items towards the end of the test, particularly items in the constructed response format rather than the multiple-choice format. These items are designed to differentiate student performance for the more proficient students. The challenging items provide those students with opportunities to apply their existing knowledge and skills to solve problems.

Typically, item complexity was increased by presenting the problem in a manner that students may not have been familiar with, the addition of some complicating detail or targeting known weaknesses. For example, Item 33 required the students to use their concept of 'time' to solve a time-related problem that contained some subtle complexities. It required an understanding of time, an ability to conceptualise the problem by processing all of the information contained (not just key words), and then solve the problem. Students with a good knowledge of a range of concepts who are confident in using these in a variety of contexts are more likely to solve these items.

Item 36 was more demanding than other items (3% answered correctly), but the omit rate remained the same (8%). It is likely that this was because the numbers and words in the item were student friendly and the topic was engaging. This was sufficient to cause more students to attempt it than might have otherwise.

Schools and teachers can use overall performance data for Queensland and Australia to compare against their own data in SunLANDA. They can also use this to evaluate how difficult a particular aspect of numeracy was for all Queensland Year 3 students. If teachers combine this with similar data from previous NAPLAN tests, they can judge for themselves the teaching priorities for various concepts and skills.

For example, many teachers would expect most Year 3 students to be able to perform a subtraction operation with two-digit numbers; however, the data shows that when subtraction is presented as a missing addend, as it was for Item 35, many students made an error. They don't link addition to subtraction. They have not internalised the inverse connection between the two operations. This year only 11% of Queensland students answered this correctly, and 8% failed to

provide a response. Item 35 also had added complexity. Students had to calculate the total rainfall in June and July before subtracting from total winter rainfall.

Teachers may want to look at their class results and compare how their students performed on this item. 'Comparison' and 'missing addend subtraction' problems are usually more challenging than the straight 'take-away' problems.

Implications for teaching

There was evidence that students understood basic mathematics content – for example, that fractions are parts of a whole – but were unable to use this knowledge to solve a problem. Teachers should begin to incorporate problem-solving into their maths lessons to assist students to become familiar with solving problems related to the maths they are learning at the time rather than dealing with problem solving as a separate concept. Including problem-solving strategies into mathematics lessons more routinely may help students link the concepts and skills of mathematics to problem-solving in a numeracy context.

Testwiseness

There is evidence that students are scanning for key words or only for numerals to process. Teachers should be wary of teaching students to solve problems based on key words. In a test situation, this is often misleading. In Item 24 for example, it is likely that many students answered incorrectly because they did not recognise this as a subtraction problem due to the language used – 'how many more?'

Furthermore, there are difficulties with this strategy for older students when crucial information is inferred and not made explicit. Students will benefit more from strategies and tools that promote an understanding of the problem through visualising or use of models.

Student responses to the distractor options in the items show that many of them are not routinely checking their answers for reasonableness. Students should be encouraged to make it a habit to consider their answers for reasonableness.

While the omission rates were not as high in Year 3 as in some of the other year levels, many students may benefit from hints about how to pace their test experience to allow more time for the most challenging questions at the end of the test.

QCAA resources

Please refer to SunLANDA, which is available to schools via the QCAA Portal on the QCAA website through the school BIC and password. The SunLANDA program displays the school's results but also links to detailed analysis of every item on the NAPLAN test. The analyses include Australian Curriculum links, language resource texts and other QCAA materials. The item analysis is also available collected into PDF format on the NAPLAN pages of the QCAA website.